COMMERCIAL CONVERSATIONS

The Buyer Opened the Proposal. The Project Still Has a Problem.

How to follow up when the person who likes your work still has to get a decision through the business.



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Your contact at a hotel has opened the proposal. The sales rep wants to send "just checking in" on Thursday. The hotel's project director has a meeting on Friday with finance and the general manager. She needs to compare replacing all the lobby fixtures now with keeping part of the existing system and doing the rest next year. Your proposal has two prices, one opening date and no description of how either option affects operations.

She could reply to your email. She still needs an answer to put in front of the people who approve the project.

A useful proposal follow-up names the decision the buyer is working on, gives them something that helps, and asks one question they can answer. Look for a missing comparison, unresolved condition, or changed date. If the proposal itself caused the confusion, fix the relevant section and send the buyer the updated version.

What should you find out before following up?

Check what the buyer said would happen next, who else needs to agree, and what those people need. Look at the proposal and previous exchange. An email open can tell you very little about whether someone has the information or authority to proceed.

Your airline moves the flight and the new arrival time means you might miss a meeting. The useful message tells you what changed and how to find another flight. Delta's schedule-change guidance lets travelers look up their updated itinerary and search for alternatives in the app or My Trips. The lesson for a proposal follow-up is to pair news with the choice it creates. If a delivery date moves, give the buyer a way to see which option still works. Delta's guidance on schedule changes

Suppose the hotel's supplier can still hold the original delivery window for one option, but the other option would need a later installation. Put those consequences in the follow-up. Say which dates are confirmed and how long the offer can be held. Ask which condition matters for the board discussion. If availability is uncertain, say when you can confirm it and what the buyer can decide in the meantime.

What should a useful proposal follow-up say?

Name the open choice in the first sentence. Add the comparison, answer, or record that lets the buyer do something. Use one request that matches the stage. Include a change in scope or price in the proposal itself so the message and the document can be forwarded together.

For the hotel, a useful message might read:

> For Friday's meeting, I've put the two lobby options on one page. The full replacement includes two overnight closures. Reusing the existing controls keeps the lobby open, subject to the controls check on site. The revised page shows what each price includes. Is keeping the lobby open the requirement we should price around?

The closures and conditions are illustrative. In a real follow-up, the details belong there only after someone responsible has verified them. If the hotel's team asked to compare the total cost over two years, show that comparison with its assumptions. If a decision belongs to finance, give your contact a short explanation they can forward.

What if your contact has to defend the decision internally?

Give them the comparison their colleagues will need. The finance team may want to see what the lower initial price leaves for next year. The general manager may need to know whether the lobby closes and when. A one-page comparison can put initial cost, deferred work, operating disruption and open assumptions together. It gives your contact a way to answer both questions without retelling your presentation.

If one option relies on reusing existing equipment, state what happens if the check fails. The buyer can then approve the inspection, approve a conditional budget, or choose the other option. A good follow-up may produce a smaller decision than the rep hoped for. That can be the decision the buying team is actually ready to make.

What's holding up the decision	What to send
Two prices cover different services.	One page showing what each option includes and what the buyer would need to buy separately.
The buyer's committee needs a reference.	A comparable project with your scope and an approved route to a reference.
The project is paused until a lease is signed.	Confirmation of the next date or event, and which terms may need refreshing then.
The firm's estimate assumed two site visits and the buyer expected ongoing supervision.	A revised scope page and a direct question about the level of support they need.

When should you change the proposal or stop sending reminders?

Change the proposal when a decision turns on something it leaves ambiguous or when a material condition has changed. Pause active follow-up when the buyer has named a genuine waiting point, declined, or asked for time. Record the event that makes the conversation useful again.

A **Follow-Up Decision Record** can be short. For the hotel, note who decides, when they meet, the question that remains, what you sent to resolve it, and when you'll review the decision. If the meeting is postponed until a budget review next month, keep the date and price validity in that record. If the buyer asks for a revised scope now, bring delivery into the answer before promising anything new.

A good measure is whether a buyer can take a meaningful step. Look for a clarified requirement, an informed decision, a specific pause, or a confirmed next conversation. A reply saying "still reviewing" has limited value when it leaves the same uncertainty in place.

Three things to check before sending.

- Know the decision the buyer is trying to make.
- Add evidence, an option, or a clarification that changes what they can do.
- Ask one question and record what should happen next.

On Friday, the hotel's project director can take a page into the meeting that explains what the price changes and what happens in the lobby. That is what she needed when she opened the proposal.

Frequently asked questions

How many days should you wait before following up?

Start with the timing agreed with the buyer and the decision they need to make. Follow up earlier if new information changes price, availability, or a deadline. If timing is unclear, use a brief message to establish it.

Can proposal follow-up be automated?

A tool can remind the team about an agreed date or help retrieve the latest proposal. A person should check changes in scope, price, and timing before sending information the buyer will rely on.

What if the buyer never replies?

Use a reasonable follow-up tied to the decision and offer a way to pause. Record the outcome based on what you know. Review patterns across deals before inferring why a particular buyer went quiet.

Delta is a public example. The hotel proposal, message and dates are illustrative.